The meeting was held as scheduled. Ratan did not attend it because, as he said in an email to CEO of JLR Daniel Smith: ‘Bender had told me brusquely that I was not required.’ He added that he had ‘nothing to hide’. The meeting was attended by Kant, Soonawala, Ramakrishnan, Gandhi and Hussain. In the mail to Smith, Ratan also added that during the meeting, the British side ‘had no specific well thought-out issue which they wanted to raise’.

Meanwhile, JLR’s financial situation grew worse. Ratan then wrote to Prime Minister Brown in February 2009, drawing his attention to the precarious situation that JLR could find itself in as it was ‘virtually impossible for Tata Motors or even Tata Sons’ to access credit for the car maker.

He also clarified that he was seeking the British government’s intervention to obtain credit as it owned a ‘major part of the larger banks’. (During the financial crisis of 2008, the British government had recapitalized some ailing banks and nationalized them.)

Ratan informed Brown that in the last seven months since it acquired JLR, the Tata Group had invested £850 million in the company. Its present requirement was for an additional £800 million to see the company ‘through the current year’.

Ratan was also encouraged to make the request to the British government as it was not unusual for the European governments, notably France and Germany, to support their industries. The letter did elicit a reply but it did not bring good tidings. The answer was: ‘Please be assured that Peter Mandelson is fully involved.’ The Prime Minister was too preoccupied with steering the country out of recession to pay much heed to Ratan’s pleas.

Ratan was exercised by the possible consequences of not being able to access the much-needed funds. He told *The Sunday Times*: ‘I would like to see us coming out of the recession with these new products in place. What would be sad—remorseful—is if the meltdown continues and we can’t get access to funds. I would like to see the British government playing only one role. It controls the banks and all I seek is the facilitation to provide access to credit on commercial terms.’

He also opined that the British government was scarcely doing anything worthwhile to promote manufacturing in the UK. He expressed his incredulity at the government’s approach, saying, ‘We’re responsible for the fortunes of the company but it is a bone-dry situation in terms of access to